

Paris Paralympics bronze medallist Mona Agarwal hopes for sustained support for parasports



At the *Sportstar Sports Conclave - Focus Rajasthan*, held at Poornima University, Jaipur, Paris Paralympics 2024 bronze medallist shooter Mona Agarwal shared the challenges she faced with equipment upgrades before the event. "The government's schemes are good, but many athletes don't receive the necessary support. I secured a Paralympic quota in March but struggled for six months to upgrade my equipment, eventually competing with basic gear," said Mona during a panel moderated by Suresh Balakrishna, Chief Revenue Officer of *The Hindu Group*.

Mona, who began shooting in December 2021 after participating in powerlifting, volleyball, and athletics since 2016, highlighted societal barriers that deter women from sports. "Progress for women is difficult to accept here, and many face hurdles they can't overcome. More women need opportunities," she stated.

Former squash international Surbhi Misra, head of the Surbhi Misra Foundation, echoed Mona's concerns, citing limited corporate and government aid. "Support exists but is barely sufficient. Corporations should focus on specific sports. Spreading thin leads to reduced outcomes," she noted, adding, "What we need is for corporations to choose a few sports. When you try to take up too many sports, it does not work. The government cannot do everything. [For example], they give us Rs 2 crore and want six medals in return. And if the success does not come, the funds go down next time. The players also say the same. It is us pushing them. Another problem then is to go to the

(L-R) Manjusha Kanwar (DGM, Sports – IndianOil), Surbhi Misra (Squash international), Anupam Nidhi (CSR Head, Vedanta Group & Hindustan Zinc) and Mona Agarwal (Paris Paralympics bronze medallist in shooting) in conversation with Suresh Balakrishna, Chief Revenue Officer of The Hindu Group. R. V. MOORTHY

grassroots. We are looking at just 30-40 players, what about the next crop? We need to work on the next generation."

Anupam Nidhi, Hindustan Zinc's CSR Head, emphasised grassroots success with the Zinc Football Academy, which has produced players like Mohammed Kaif, part of India's U-17 SAFF Championship squad. "Infrastructure, coaching, and technology are key. Our holistic approach has brought results," said Nidhi. She pointed out India's underinvestment in sports, citing a CSR spend of about one per cent in sports out of an overall Rs 25,000 CSR spend.

Commonwealth medallist Manjusha Kanwar, now DGM - Sports at Indian Oil, shared that corporate focus on women's sports has increased, driven by Olympic successes. "At Indian Oil, women receive equal priority. We've also invested in para scholarships with equal distribution for men and women," she said. To boost grassroots engagement, Manjusha urged deeper outreach into districts and villages and stressed that the government and stakeholders must collaborate effectively, and allocate clear roles to avoid repetition.

